



FREE SPIRIT

Whether you are a teetotaler or experimenting with sobriety, there are a range of alcohol-free drinks from zero per cent beer to gin to keep you excited

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WHEN thirty-two-year-old Yashika Sharma, a Gurugram-based advertising professional, planned her baby shower this April, she was clear about one thing—if she wasn't going to drink, neither were her guests. At the same time, she didn't want to serve the regular colas, fruit juices or *nimboo pani*. "I ordered a selection of zero-alcohol beverages including beer, gin, cocktails and even wine," says the soon-to-be-mother, adding: "They tasted great, some of them just like the real thing, and we could party without getting drunk."

Globally, there is a spike in the consumption of zero-proof or non-alcoholic beverages. With a growing number of teetotalers, health-conscious millennials and the 'sober curious'—those exploring elements of a booze-free lifestyle without fully abstaining—the market for crafted beverages with organic ingredients and avant-garde flavour profiles is growing. Non-alcoholic beverage sales increased 33 per cent to \$331 million in the US in 2021, according to data from NielsenIQ. They did especially well on e-commerce platforms—there was a 315 per cent increase